Dancing with a Devil

By Brooke Berman

WOMAN: I am 24 years old, and I live in New York City. My life is shiny and new, and just barely discovered. I am an emerging something or other, waiting tables and writing stories. I go to parties with people whose skin sparkles and whose names are known. I like to tell stories about how I am 24 years old and still a virgin, deconstructing the relationship between my heart and my skin and my sex.

INTRODUCTION

In this selection, a young woman moves to the city so she can pretend to live life on the edge . . . She finds out she is not as safe as she had believed. Dancing with a Devil by Brooke Berman

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WOMAN: I like to dance, to feel air inside my body. I think that dancing will save me from pain. The music will earth me and the beat will bring me to the ground. I go dancing in gay bars with funny names. I take great pleasure being a girl in a boy-bar, enjoying the fact no one is going to try and pick me up. My life is safe. I play outrageous, but my life is safe . . . because I have made it that way. Just enough outrage, and lots of safety nets.

On the first day of the new year, I write down a list of my dreams and goals. I have many dreams, the foremost of which is this. "I want to be transformed." I write it down: "I want to be transformed." Because that is what I want.

I look for transformation anywhere I can. I look for it in the eyes of other people, but I don't see it there. I look for it in the mountains in New Mexico, in the water of the hot springs, in the air of New York City and in the words that come to me while I dream.

It is June, I am 24, and I am about to be transformed. (PAUSE)

It's June, June 19th to be precise, just barely after midnight. And I am about to fall asleep in my safe bed, in my safe SoHo fourth floor walk up. It's four in the morning and I open my eyes, certain that Sarah, my old roommate, has come home, though she moved out months ago and this makes no sense. I am sure that Sarah is in the apartment and I open my eyes, fully believing I will see her there.

But I don't see Sarah. I see someone I do not know. I open my eyes to a stranger standing at the foot of my bed wearing a little black half mask and a black turtleneck, looking a little bit like Zorro or like an existentialist Lone Ranger, and I cannot understand how this stranger has penetrated my sleep or entered my apartment.

The stranger just stares at me. He doesn't move. He says, "Good evening." And then the stranger moves towards me very, very slowly, like in slow motion and I understand everything that is about to happen. I understand it in my mind before he even touches me. I think: "This can't happen to me." I think this can't happen to me because I am very smart. I have read Roland Barthes and I know how to deconstruct sexuality. I am a virgin, and I am very smart, and things like this aren't supposed to happen to people like me.

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The stranger says, "Everything will change now, everything about you will change, you will no longer be who you were, you will have to become someone else to even understand this, to even put it behind you. You will leave your friends, your home, your family in order to become a person who can put this behind herself. I am the answer to your prayers. I am giving you what you asked for. I am giving you the gift of transformation."

But I don't want to transform. Not like this. I don't want to go through with it.

I am dancing with the devil right now in a time that lasts longer than ordinary time.

It was all over quickly. It seemed to take a long time, but I know that in the reality we call reality, it happened within the span of ten, maybe 15, minutes. He turned me over like some object and covered my head with a pillow and stuck his rage and his pain all inside me, and then it was over. And he was gone, as quietly and mysteriously as he came. He came out of the night and went back inside of it and was never caught.

I have taken the pain of some man that I do not know inside of me. I have taken it inside and transformed it . . . inside. I have go to rape crisis centers and to therapy and to psychic healing in order to transform the pain he stuck inside me one morning. Me, a stranger. I carry energy inside of me, some of which you deposited there. Rapists don't use protection.

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But I am not a repository for some stranger's suffering. Do you hear me? I DON'T WANT YOUR SUFFERING. YOU CAN JUST PUT IT SOMEWHERE ELSE, AND I HOPE THAT YOU SUFFER TIL THE END OF TIME, TIL THE END OF EVERYTHING. MAY YOUR SOULD KNOW WHAT YOU HAVE DONE TO ME AND MAY YOU . . . MAY you . . . may you be healed.

Everything will change, he said. And it did.

I am not 24 years old anymore. I have changed. I do not know the people I knew then. My friends are different, my work is different. I have lived in seven different apartments in the last three years. I do no live along. I sleep with a nightlight.

I am a statistic. How many women in ten? I meet young women who remind me of myself, before it happened, and they scare me. I am afraid that something will cause them to leave a piece of themselves behind forever. I hope not. But . . . . everything has changed. Except that I still wake up at four in the morning expecting to find him there.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Brooke Berman
Book: Humana Festival 1999: The Complete Plays
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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006, National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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